

# Digital Cameras

I've got a hankering for the perfect picture

One of my friends wanted a camera, and as luck would have it, I was on my way out to get one for a colleague when I got that call...

Previously, anyone wanting a digital camera would be pointed towards the *de facto* 5 to 7 megapixel camera with a 3x optical zoom. But needs differ, and vendors have done well to recognise this fact. Although the larger semi-professional DSLR cameras have always had a multitude of settings in their exhaustive and sometimes complicated menus, I've found compact cameras to lack many options—either in their menus or in terms of usability. The compact cameras today are another story. I did a little surfing and came up with quite a few cameras that were refreshingly different. There are the ultra zoom models—cameras with optical zoom (ignore digital zoom claims please) in the region of 6x to 12x, as well as some compacts with smaller zooms, but large resolution image sensors. Then there are the ultra compacts—about as big as the average cell phone.

Vendors will have you believe that Kodak, Fuji and Nikon are entry level or mid-range offerings—though this isn't true—probably because of the cheaper models they stock from these brands. One vendor told me, "People who want higher-end models usually ask for Canon or Sony, while those looking for a budget camera prefer Kodak and Nikon." My advice: ignore what vendors tell you—most of them really don't know what they're talking about. Before you go out and buy a camera, do your research, read our reviews and make up your own mind.

Among the ultra compacts, the first brand worth mentioning was Canon with their Digital IXUS series. The IXUS 800IS, 860IS, 900Ti and 950IS were all on display. The 800IS is based around a smaller 6 megapixel image sensor and priced at Rs 12,000, while the 950IS is based around a larger 8 megapixel sensor and priced at Rs 16,000. Both cameras sport an optical zoom of 4X—good for an ultra compact camera, but strictly ordinary for a regular digital camera. The more expensive SD 900Ti isn't necessarily a better camera

with a 3x optical zoom and a macro shooting range of not less than 5 cm. Its selling point is the titanium body, which isn't worth it at Rs 18,000. The newer IXUS 860IS is available for Rs 15,500 and features a 3.8X optical zoom. Sony's T series of cameras is even more attractive. For one, they are tinier than Canon's offerings, and come in different colours. They also have all the features that some larger cameras lack—like the 5x optical zoom on the Cybershot T300 (10 MP) and T200 (8.1 MP). Both feature Sony's patented double anti-shake blur reduction, which is fancy handle for optical and digital image stabilisation systems that these cameras integrate. At Rs 18,000 for



the T300, and Rs 17,500 for the T200, these cameras vie for your cash. In addition, the T200 features a touch screen, something nifty to watch out for.

Among the entry-level cameras, Nikon's Coolpix L16 and L18 are available at Rs 6,000 and Rs 6,800, respectively. Both have 3X optical zooms, the former is a 7 megapixel camera, while the latter is rated at 8 megapixels. Kodak's C713 (7 megapixel, 3X optical zoom) is available at Rs 5,000 and should be the minimum you should settle for. Canon's A470 was also on display, 7 megapixels and a 3.4x optical zoom for Rs 5,500.

Among the ultra zoom models, Kodak's ZD710 (Rs 9000) is a spanking new model with a 7 megapixel sensor and a large 10X optical zoom. Even more capable is Canon's SX100IS, which also has a 10X zoom and a slightly larger sensor at 8 megapixels. Priced

well at Rs 12,500, it also features image stabilisation, which is a plus when using such long zooms. The largest zoom-bearing model I could find was the Nikon P80, which astonishingly enough features a large 10 MP rated sensor and an 18X optical zoom. It's priced well at Rs 16,000.

Among the regular cameras Sony's W300 impressed me with its sleek titanium-coated body, and a whopping 13.6 megapixel sensor and 3X zoom. Priced at Rs 16,800, this camera is great for those looking for something compact yet powerful. The W200 (12.1 MP, 3X zoom, Rs 14,720) and W120 (7 MP, 4X zoom, Rs 9,000) were also on display although the latter (W120) isn't as impressively built as the other two. Nikon's P50 (8.1 MP, 3.6X zoom, Rs 8,800) was another well built, well laid-out camera and has a better grip for shooting than the flat, compact Sony's, but isn't as pocketable. The P5100 adds a larger sensor, that is, 10 MP to the P50. The zoom is identical, as is build quality, with a price of Rs 11,700. Olympus's FE310 is one of their entry level offerings with some impressive specifications at 8 MP, 5X zoom. It's priced extremely well at Rs 6,600. The only minus is Olympus' proprietary memory standard—xD cards. Canon's A720IS was on display—a successor to my now old A710IS. At Rs 10,400, and with an 8 MP sensor and 6X zoom, the A720IS is a well-built and well-balanced camera in terms of features and performance. A whopping 12 MP rated A650IS, also features a 6X zoom and is priced at Rs 14,000. This one also has a larger grip, a consequence of it requiring four AA batteries, rather than two, and features a swivel viewfinder display. The A580 (8 MP, 4X zoom) was priced at Rs 7,700 and the A590IS (8 MP, 4X zoom) was priced at Rs 8,600. Kodak's M893IS is a neat looking camera (8 MP, 3X zoom), but it's not as well built as some of the others.

I recommended the all round capabilities of the Canon Powershot SX100IS to my friend and he decided to pick it up for this price. My colleague at office decided he didn't want the extra zoom and went for the A720IS, another great all rounder. ☐

agent001@thinkdigit.com

## Going Pro

**Q** I am buying a new PC. Which CPU is better—Quad-Core Q6600 (2.4 GHz) or Core 2 Duo E8500 (3.16 GHz)? What is the difference in performance of both? Please suggest a good motherboard and a good 3D solution also. I also need a good cabinet and power supply to go along with the rest of the system. My target is Hardcore Gaming and support Vista Ultimate, 3D photo and video editing, recent Linux OS like Ubuntu, Fedora, Mandrake etc.

Souvik Mukherjee

**A** You haven't mentioned a budget for your PC. Also, since you seem a lot more interested in Linux than gaming, I'm assuming gaming takes second position to programming and such. Based on your needs, I'm recommending a configuration for you. Along with the components mentioned, I'm suggesting memory as well. As far as your query goes, a quad-core is meant for those who are heavily into multi-tasking. Very few applications that home PC users use are coded to utilise four cores properly, so a dual-core is enough for most users, and some applications that benefit from clock speed increments will do better on dual cores which traditionally have faster clocks than quad cores. For gaming dual cores are mostly faster except for a few of the latest games which are coded to take advantage of the two extra cores.

| Basic Gaming PC |                             |              |
|-----------------|-----------------------------|--------------|
| Component       | Suggestion                  | Approx Price |
| Processor       | Core 2 Duo E8400 (3.00 GHz) | Rs 9,000     |
| Motherboard     | Abit IP35-E Off Limits      | Rs 5,000     |
| RAM             | 2x1 GB DDR2 667 (Transcend) | Rs 1,950     |
| Graphics Card   | Gigabyte GeForce 8800GT     | Rs 11,000    |
| Hard Drive      | Seagate 7200.10 250 GB      | Rs 2,200     |
| Total Price     |                             | Rs 29,150    |

This configuration will give you a lot of processing power and a good graphics solution. In case you want more storage you could opt for a 500 GB hard drive for around Rs 3,900.

## Best All-rounder

**Q** I am looking for a cellphone. My budget is around Rs 10-11,000. It must have a good camera, sound, screen, multimedia capabilities and almost everything. I have selected SE K790i, Nokia 5700, and Motorola MOTOROKR E6. Are there any better models other than these in the market? Which one do you recommend? Your recommendation is all that matters.

Nitish

**A** I've used SEs K790i and have nothing but praise for the phone. It's got a good antenna that gives great voice clarity, battery life is good, and the screen is crisp and colourful. Music playback and camera quality are also top-

notch. In comparison, the Nokia 5700 and Motorola E6 lag far behind. To add to the K790i's list of advantages its light and ultra compact. A cheaper option to the K790i is the K800i, which lacks EDGE support, which is useless for most people anyway. Expect to pay around Rs 10K for the K790i and Rs 8K for the K800i.

## Rocking In The Budget World

**Q** Hi, I am a big fan of *Digit* and have been reading it since Standard 3. This is my first query letter to *Digit*. I want to buy a flash based MP3 player between Rs 8,000-12,000. I want decent playback quality, video support, easy user interface, FM, FM recording and voice recording capabilities. I would like one which looks nice. I do not want to buy an iPod. I have shortlisted the Cowon D2 and Creative Muvo T200 (don't ask why this). Is the Cowon D2 a good choice? If so what is its official price?

Dhiraj Agrawal

**A** I'm curious to know why you do not want to buy an iPod. The iPod Touch is a great sounding, fully functional PMP. Of course, it's beyond your price range as well. The Cowon D2 is an amazing PMP. Great quality and what's more impressive is a vast array of features in addition to the ones you mentioned above. The great plus point being memory expansion via SD as 8 GB cards have become quite cheap. The D2 also has amazing battery life.

The last I checked the street price of the Cowon D2 was around Rs 9,000 for the 4 GB version. You can buy it eyes closed.

## Overhaul!

**Q** I want to change my MSI 480 motherboard. Do the new AM2 boards support AMD Athlon 64 socket 939 processor or I have to replace the processor as well? Let me know my options along with the product available in the market.

Dipak Kumar Show

**A** No, the new AM2 boards are 940 pin-based and support DDR2 RAM. So if you want to upgrade, you will not only be buying a new motherboard, but a new processor and memory as well. If you are buying all three components anyway, then I suggest you invest in an Intel-based system, as you'll get better bang for your buck. I'd recommend an Intel P35 chipset based board—look for the Abit IP35-E, available for Rs 5,000. For the processor look for a Core 2 Duo E2180 if you're looking for extreme value; if you want performance, look at the Core 2 Duo E8400 for Rs 9,000. I recommend 2 GB of DDR2 RAM—look for a frequency of 667 MHz. Brands to look at are Transcend and Kingston. Expect to pay around Rs 1,900 for 2 GB. If, however you're looking only to replace your motherboard and not your CPU or memory, take a look at NVIDIA's GeForce 6100 / 6150 based chipsets. Expect to pay up to Rs 3,000. ☐

**Ask Away!**

Want a tech product, but don't know how to go about buying it? E-mail agent001@thinkdigit.com with your complete contact details, and he might answer them here! Please note that Agent001 only answers purchase-related questions in this space.